

Why People Hurt People

DURATION	35–40 min · Week 2
OBJECTIVE	Students identify at least two reasons people cause hurt to others and explain how understanding reasons does not excuse harm but can reduce the weight of it.
CASEL FOCUS	Social Awareness: perspective-taking and empathy · Responsible Decision-Making: evaluating behavior in context
VOCABULARY	perspective, intent, impact, empathy, reason, excuse
MATERIALS	Journals · Scenario cards · Anchor chart

OPENING REVIEW

2 Minutes

"Last lesson we said: your hurt is real. Today we take one step back — not to excuse the hurt, but to understand it." Can understanding why someone hurt you be the same as excusing them? [No — that is today's key distinction.]

1

Why People Hurt

2–10 MIN

People cause hurt for reasons: they are hurting themselves / they want power and don't know another way / they feel embarrassed or defensive / they were taught this is how people treat each other / they did not understand the impact. "None of these is an excuse. But all of them are explanations."

2

Intent vs. Impact

10–18 MIN

Intent is what the person meant to do. Impact is what happened to you. A person can cause significant hurt without intending to — and the hurt is still real. "If someone bumps into you by accident, their intent was not to hurt you — but you still fell."

3

Scenario Card Practice — Pairs

18–30 MIN

What might the person who caused harm have been feeling? Does understanding that change how you feel about what happened?

4

Journal

30–37 MIN

Think of a time you were hurt. What might the other person have been going through? "People are rarely mean because you deserved it. They are usually mean because of something going on in them."